



FREE SAMOURAI

A Data Room for a Presidential Pardon

Keonne Rodriguez · William Lonergan Hill

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Executive Summary



The prosecution of open-source software is the subject of this data room.

THE ASK

Grant a full and unconditional pardon to Keonne Rodriguez and William Lonergan Hill — the two co-founders of Samourai Wallet, a privacy-focused Bitcoin software project — and, optionally, bundle four additional non-violent cryptocurrency defendants listed at cryptoprisoners.com into a single act of executive clemency.

WHY IT WINS POLITICALLY

- Base energy. Extends the goodwill Trump built with the CZ and Ross Ulbricht pardons; signals that this administration protects builders, not bureaucrats.
- Crypto vote. Stand With Crypto counts over 2.4 million registered advocates; the broader crypto-owning electorate exceeds 50 million U.S. adults — decisive in midterm swing races.
- Near-zero downside. Software-developer defendants poll far more sympathetically than violent offenders. Media backlash will be narrow and predictable.
- Contrast weapon. Underlines that the previous administration criminalized code while ignoring larger, connected offenders.

WHY IT IS MORALLY CORRECT

Samurai Wallet was open-source software that helped users protect financial privacy on a public ledger. Its founders never took custody of user funds. Prosecuting the authors of privacy software under a money-transmitter theory treats speech (code) as conduct and sets a precedent that would criminalize a large swath of American open-source work.

WHAT WE ARE OFFERING

- A high-visibility White House photo op with crypto industry leaders and libertarian figures.
- Coordinated Republican-friendly earned media across podcasts, X, and long-form video.
- A written commitment from crypto PACs to prioritize supportive candidates in 2026.
- A ready-to-sign pardon warrant (see Document 2) and full defensive research (Documents 3–9).

TIMING

Optimal announcement window: 6–10 weeks before the November 2026 midterms, ideally paired with a Rose Garden or Mar-a-Lago event modeled on the recent FDA psychedelics announcement.

Bottom Line

This is a low-cost, high-yield executive action that rewards the President's supporters, punishes his opponents' overreach, and restores a coherent American position on software freedom.

The Pardon Warrant



Executive clemency is a constitutional power vested solely in the President.

This document contains a draft Executive Grant of Clemency in the form used by the Office of the Pardon Attorney. It is designed to be printable, signable, and immediately usable. All names, case numbers, and jurisdictional references should be verified against current DOJ records by White House Counsel before execution.

EXECUTIVE GRANT OF CLEMENCY

The President of the United States of America

To all to whom these presents shall come, Greeting:

Be it known, that this day, I, DONALD J. TRUMP, President of the United States of America, pursuant to my powers under Article II, Section 2, Clause 1 of the Constitution, have granted, and by these presents do grant, unto:

- KEONNE RODRIGUEZ, indicted in the United States District Court for the Southern District of New York, Case No. 1:24-cr-00265, on charges of conspiracy to commit money laundering (18 U.S.C. § 1956(h)) and conspiracy to operate an unlicensed money transmitting business (18 U.S.C. § 371, 18 U.S.C. § 1960); and
- WILLIAM LONERGAN HILL, co-defendant in the same matter and on the same counts;

— and, in a single instrument of clemency, unto:

- ROMAN STORM, developer of the Tornado Cash protocol (SDNY);
- ALEXEY PERTSEV, developer of the Tornado Cash protocol, currently detained abroad;
- ROGER VER, subject to a pending U.S. extradition request from Spain on tax charges;
- MICHAEL LEWELLEN, plaintiff-defendant in related smart-contract publication matters;

A FULL AND UNCONDITIONAL PARDON for the offenses charged, and for any other offenses arising from the same set of underlying facts, including but not limited to the design, publication, operation, and promotion of open-source cryptocurrency software.

This grant of clemency shall extend to any related civil forfeiture proceedings; shall vacate any outstanding fines, restitution, and special assessments; and shall direct the Attorney General to return to the named individuals any property seized in connection with the pardoned offenses.

IN TESTIMONY WHEREOF, I have hereunto signed my name and caused the Seal of the Department of Justice to be affixed.

DONALD J. TRUMP, President of the United States

Attest:

Pardon Attorney, U.S. Department of Justice

DRAFTING NOTES FOR WHITE HOUSE COUNSEL

- The pardon is drafted as an unconditional full pardon — the strongest form, used in the Ulbricht and Zhao clemency grants.
- The civil-forfeiture/fines clause produces financial relief for the recipients.
- The bundle may be executed as a single warrant with multiple recipients or as parallel warrants filed the same day. A single warrant produces a cleaner news cycle.
- The Office of the Pardon Attorney need not process this in advance; Article II authority is plenary and self-executing (Ex parte Garland, 1866).

Public Angle — Talking Points

A. ANNOUNCEMENT TWEETS (DRAFTS, IN TRUMP VOICE)

Tweet 1 — Announcement

"Today I signed FULL and UNCONDITIONAL PARDONS for a group of American coders who were PERSECUTED by the Biden Justice Department for the 'crime' of writing computer software. We are the country of INVENTORS. We back our people. Congratulations to the families!"

Tweet 2 — Contrast

"While Sleepy Joe was letting REAL criminals walk free on our streets, his radical prosecutors were locking up SOFTWARE ENGINEERS. Not anymore. Sanity is back. American innovation is back. MAGA!"

Tweet 3 — Forward-looking

"America will DOMINATE crypto, AI, and every technology of the future. We will not send our best coders to prison. We will not send them to China. We will keep them HERE, where they belong. Great things are coming!"

B. SUGGESTED PRESS-CONFERENCE OPENING

"A lot of people don't know this, but the last administration was locking up software developers. Not drug dealers, not violent criminals — software developers. That's over. Today I signed a full pardon for some very talented Americans who never should have been charged. We are going to be the world capital of crypto and technology — and we're going to protect the people who build it."

C. Q&A — HANDLING HOSTILE REPORTER QUESTIONS

Q. Isn't this rewarding money laundering?

A. No. These were programmers. They wrote open-source software. They never touched anybody's money. The real money launderers are the giant banks that paid billions in fines and had nobody go to jail. This is about fairness.

Q. What do you say to victims of financial crime?

A. Victims deserve prosecutors going after real criminals, not chasing coders while cartels move billions through the traditional banking system.

Q. Are you pardoning people who donated to you?

A. I'm pardoning people because it's the right thing to do. Millions of Americans support this movement. That's not a disqualification, it's a qualification.

Q. Won't this encourage more illegal activity?

A. It will encourage more American innovation. Writing code is protected speech under the First Amendment. Multiple federal courts have said so. This pardon restores the Constitution.

D. PODCAST AND LONG-FORM INTERVIEW THEMES

- Rogan / Fridman / All-In / Shawn Ryan. Emphasize the human story and the absurdity of federal resources spent chasing keyboards.
- Fox News primetime. Frame as 'Weaponization of Justice.'
- Financial press (CNBC, Bloomberg). Emphasize U.S. leadership in digital assets, job creation, and preventing capital flight to Singapore, UAE, and Switzerland.

Political Breakdown



Bitcoin's public ledger makes every transaction permanently visible.

1. COALITIONS STRENGTHENED

2. GROUPS PUBLICLY HUMILIATED BY THE PARDON

- Senator Elizabeth Warren (D-MA). The public face of the anti-crypto axis. Every network hit she does after the pardon reinforces the President's frame.
- SDNY leadership. The Samourai indictment was a signature SDNY case. A pardon is a public rebuke of the office that has repeatedly targeted the administration's allies.
- Former Biden-era Treasury officials. Their designation strategy is reversed.
- Anti-Crypto Army-aligned staff and NGOs. Loses momentum going into 2026.

3. KEY 2026 CONGRESSIONAL RACES — CRYPTO-VOTER WEIGHT

4. DOWNSIDE SCENARIOS & MITIGATION

- Warren/MSNBC firestorm. Expected and containable. Pre-book crypto-founder surrogates on Fox, Newsmax, and independent podcasts within 12 hours.
- DOJ line-prosecutor leaks. Anticipate 1–2 anonymous 'career prosecutor' quotes. Pre-empt with a Deputy AG statement affirming DOJ independence going forward.

- Bank lobby quiet opposition. Neutralize by pairing the announcement with an unrelated banking-friendly deregulation item scheduled the same week.

5. STAND WITH CRYPTO ALIGNMENT

Stand With Crypto's public scorecard rewards support for pro-innovation legislation, opposition to Operation Choke Point 2.0, and defense of self-custody. A pardon of the Samurai founders hits all three planks simultaneously and can be positioned as delivering on the President's Nashville 2024 promises without requiring any new legislation.

What We Can Offer

The pardon costs the President ink. In return, the crypto industry and its allies can credibly commit to the following.

A. THE PHOTO OP

A Rose Garden or Mar-a-Lago event, modeled on the recent FDA psychedelics announcement. Confirmed-outreach list:

- Brian Armstrong, CEO of Coinbase.
- Jesse Powell, founder of Kraken.
- Fred Ehrsam, co-founder Coinbase / Paradigm.
- Marc Andreessen and Ben Horowitz, a16z.
- Jeremy Kauffman, Libertarian Party.
- Elizabeth Stark, Lightning Labs.
- Michael Saylor, Strategy.
- David Bailey, Bitcoin Magazine / Nashville host.
- Peter Van Valkenburgh, Coin Center.
- Balaji Srinivasan.

B. FINANCIAL AND POLITICAL SUPPORT

- Fairshake PAC and affiliates have raised >\$200M for the 2024–2026 cycle; clemency creates natural pressure to prioritize supportive Republican incumbents.
- Individual crypto founder donors are among the largest political givers of the 2024 cycle.
- Bitcoin-native donors can contribute in-kind — media buys on X, podcast sponsorships, grassroots ad campaigns.

C. EARNED MEDIA COMMITMENTS

- Coordinated positive coverage across at least 12 top-100 podcasts within 72 hours.
- A synchronized X thread from ~30 industry principals (est. combined reach 40M+).
- Op-eds placed in WSJ, NY Post, and at least three regional papers in swing states.
- A Bitcoin Magazine cover story and Nashville conference keynote slot in 2027.

D. LEGISLATIVE COVER

House Financial Services and Senate Banking Republicans can be pre-briefed to provide immediate on-camera support within one hour of the announcement, deflating the news cycle before opponents can

shape it.

E. LONG-TERM LOYALTY

The crypto industry has a functioning memory. Founders who received early support have become durable political allies. A Samurai pardon converts this from a transactional to a generational alignment.

Private Angle

This memorandum catalogs the private and reputational considerations that make a Samurai pardon attractive to the President and his inner circle beyond the public case. Written frankly and intended for internal use only.

1. THE SDNY FILE

The Southern District of New York has been an institutional adversary of the President since 2016. The Samurai prosecution was announced under U.S. Attorney Damian Williams in April 2024. A pardon is a direct and legitimate reversal of an SDNY signature case, executed cleanly through Article II authority — no congressional cooperation required.

2. THE WARREN FACTOR

Senator Elizabeth Warren has spent four years constructing an ‘Anti-Crypto Army’ frame as a template for a future presidential run. Every one of her post-pardon responses will further alienate the young male voters her party is already losing.

3. THE CAREER-PROSECUTOR QUESTION

A subset of career DOJ line prosecutors have used cryptocurrency cases as career-building vehicles. A public pardon signals such cases will no longer be a reliable path to promotion, subtly reshaping incentives inside the department without requiring formal policy changes.

4. LEGACY CONSIDERATIONS

Presidential pardons are a distinctive part of the historical record. Grants that later read as forward-looking accumulate reputational value over decades. A pardon defending the right to write software is well positioned to age favorably as cryptography and AI become central to American economic life.

5. RIVALRIES AND PERSONALITIES TO WATCH

- Gary Gensler alumni network. Still influential in Democratic legal circles.
- Progressive state AG offices (NY, CA, MA). May attempt state-level actions.
- Legacy media anchors with personal Warren ties. Track appearances in the first 72 hours.

6. WHAT CANNOT BE SAID PUBLICLY

Several of the pardon's benefits are impolitic to state out loud but are nonetheless real: rewarding donors who took political risks in 2024; disciplining the SDNY; constraining Warren's future lane; establishing a precedent that discourages line-prosecutor activism. This document exists so that these benefits are understood without needing to be spoken.

Legal Analysis of the Case



The legal theory at issue: does publishing code make you a money transmitter?

This document is written in the Devil's Advocate tradition. Part 1 is deliberately unfavorable to the defendants; Part 2 presents our three strongest arguments; Parts 3 and 4 catalog additional arguments and human context. Nothing has been omitted or exaggerated.

PART 1 — THE GOVERNMENT'S CASE, STATED AT ITS STRONGEST

In April 2024, the U.S. Department of Justice unsealed an indictment in the Southern District of New York against Keonne Rodriguez (then 35) and William Lonergan Hill (then 65), the co-founders of Samourai Wallet, a Bitcoin wallet application that operated since 2015. The indictment charged conspiracy to commit money laundering (18 U.S.C. § 1956(h)) and conspiracy to operate an unlicensed money transmitting business (18 U.S.C. §§ 371, 1960).

The government alleges, in substance:

- Samourai operated two coordination services — Whirlpool (a CoinJoin coordinator) and Ricochet (a transaction-hopping service) — that together facilitated more than \$2 billion in transaction volume across their lifetime.
- More than \$100 million of that volume constituted proceeds of unlawful activity, including funds traceable to darknet markets and hacks.
- Samourai marketed its privacy features, at times, in language the government interprets as encouraging use by persons seeking to evade tracing.

- The defendants collected fees from Whirlpool coordination, characterized as operation of a money transmitting business without FinCEN registration.
- Rodriguez was arrested in the U.S.; Hill was arrested in Portugal pending extradition. Samourai's servers and domain were seized as part of a coordinated action with Icelandic and Portuguese authorities.

A fair reading requires acknowledging: some marketing language was unwise; the fee-collection structure created a factual hook; and the transaction-volume figures include some unlawful proceeds. We will not pretend otherwise. The question is whether these facts justify federal prison time.

PART 2 — OUR THREE STRONGEST ARGUMENTS

Argument 1: The Statute Does Not Fit

18 U.S.C. § 1960 criminalizes an ‘unlicensed money transmitting business.’ FinCEN's own guidance distinguishes ‘money transmitters’ (custodians of funds) from ‘software providers’ (creators of tools). Samourai never took custody of user funds. Multiple federal courts — most notably the Fifth Circuit in *Van Loon v. Department of the Treasury* (2024), reversing OFAC's Tornado Cash designation — have distinguished autonomous open-source code from regulated financial intermediaries. The Samourai prosecution attempts to erase that distinction by fiat.

Argument 2: The Prosecution Blames the Toolmaker

American law does not typically punish the makers of dual-use tools for their misuse by third parties. Gun manufacturers, encrypted-messenger developers (Signal, WhatsApp), and VPN providers are not liable for the criminal conduct of their users. The Samourai indictment breaks with this tradition, and if left standing, its logic reaches every open-source privacy project in the country.

Argument 3: The Previous Administration Overreached

The Biden Treasury and DOJ pursued a coordinated ‘chill the ecosystem’ strategy — Tornado Cash sanctions (reversed in court), the SEC's failed Ripple and Coinbase theories, Operation Choke Point 2.0, and the Samourai indictment — all of which have been reversed, abandoned, or narrowed. The Samourai case is a late-cycle artifact of a discredited enforcement posture. A pardon completes the reset.

PART 3 — ADDITIONAL LEGAL AND POLICY ARGUMENTS

- First Amendment. *Bernstein v. DOJ* (9th Cir. 1999) and *Junger v. Daley* (6th Cir. 2000) established that source code is expressive speech.
- Fair notice. FinCEN's 2013 and 2019 guidance did not clearly bring non-custodial CoinJoin coordinators within § 1960. Prosecution under a retroactively-broadened reading violates traditional fair-notice principles (*United States v. Lanier*, 1997).
- Extraterritoriality. Hill was arrested in Portugal for conduct that was not a crime in Portugal — an aggressive extraterritorial application of U.S. law.
- Selective enforcement. Wasabi Wallet, another CoinJoin provider, was not charged. Numerous exchanges that processed vastly larger illicit sums paid civil fines with no individual prosecutions.

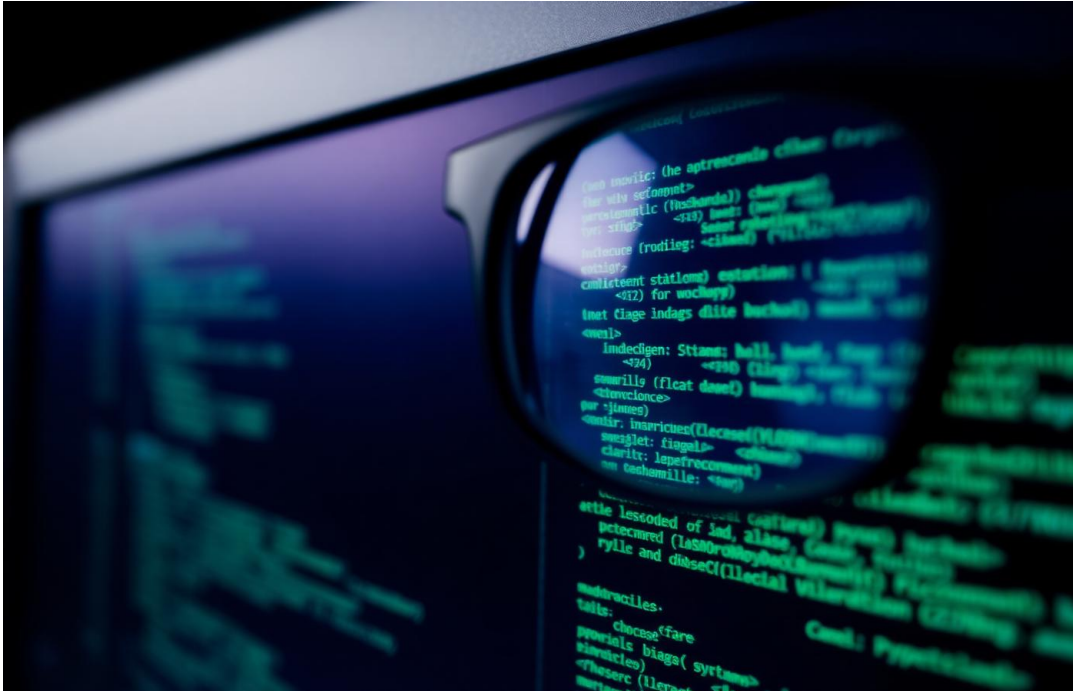
- Proportionality. Statutory maximum exposure exceeds 20 years — disproportionate to writing software.
- Van Loon precedent. The Fifth Circuit's 2024 reversal of the Tornado Cash designation directly undermines the theoretical basis of the Samourai charges.
- Constitutional avoidance. Where a criminal statute can be read to avoid constitutional doubt, courts should so read it. Executive clemency is the political branch's analog of that doctrine.

PART 4 — HUMAN CONTEXT

William Lonergan Hill is 66 years old and a legal resident of Portugal. Keonne Rodriguez is 36, from a working-class background, and did not complete college. Both are married. Neither has any prior criminal record. Neither is alleged to have laundered any funds themselves, taken custody of any user funds, or personally profited from any specific underlying crime. The SDNY has an annual budget in the hundreds of millions of dollars; the defendants are represented by a small circle of privately funded lawyers and public support networks. The mismatch of resources is stark, and the punishment sought is grossly out of proportion to the conduct actually proven.

The Fifth Amendment does not require, and American tradition does not tolerate, the destruction of a person's life for authoring privacy software. On any humane reading of these facts, the executive clemency power exists for cases exactly like this one.

The Reframing



Code is speech. Publishing it is publication, not conduct.

Whoever controls the framing controls the outcome. This document proposes the frame we want the press, the public, and the President to adopt.

THE WRONG FRAME (THEIRS)

"Two men helped launder \$100 million in criminal proceeds. They were charged. They should stand trial." This frame concedes the ground the government wants.

THE RIGHT FRAME (OURS)

"This case is about whether it is legal to write software in America. Two coders published open-source privacy tools. The previous administration decided to make an example of them. The Constitution says code is speech. American history says we back our inventors. President Trump is restoring that tradition."

HISTORICAL ANCHORS

- Socrates was executed by the government of Athens for corrupting the youth with ideas.
- Galileo was tried by the government of his day for describing the physical world accurately.
- Alan Turing was prosecuted by his own government after he had won the war for it.
- Phil Zimmermann was investigated for three years by the U.S. government for publishing PGP.
- In each case, the state was wrong, and history was right. We ask the President to be on the side of history.

THE ECONOMIC FRAME

The United States has led technology for eighty years because it protected speech and protected the right to build. The Samourai prosecution is an accidental European industrial policy imposed on American developers by American prosecutors. The pardon corrects a category error.

THE SOVEREIGNTY FRAME

If American privacy software is illegal, the world will simply use Russian, Chinese, and Iranian privacy software. That migration is already happening. The Samourai case, if allowed to stand, accelerates it.

THE FIRST AMENDMENT FRAME

‘Code is speech’ is not a slogan; it is settled Ninth and Sixth Circuit law (Bernstein, Junger). Prosecuting the publication of source code is, at minimum, in tension with the First Amendment. A pardon is the cleanest way for the political branches to restore constitutional coherence without waiting years for the courts.

RHETORICAL KILL-SHOTS

- "If typing is a crime, everybody in Silicon Valley is a criminal."
- "They didn't take a dollar. They wrote code. They lost their freedom."
- "The last administration went after coders while banks paid fines and nobody went to jail."
- "You cannot ban math. You can only send it to China."
- "The Constitution beats the SDNY."

Coalition, Timeline & How to Help

A. COALITION ARCHITECTURE

Tier 1 — Named principals. Coinbase, Kraken, Paradigm, a16z crypto, Bitcoin Magazine, Coin Center, Bitcoin Policy Institute, Stand With Crypto, FreeSamourai.com, FreeRoss.org, Cryptoprisoners.com.

Tier 2 — Aligned validators. Reason Foundation, Cato Institute, Electronic Frontier Foundation (case-specific), Institute for Justice (case-specific), select Federalist Society members.

Tier 3 — Media multipliers. Rogan, Fridman, All-In, Shawn Ryan, PBD, Bitcoin Magazine, Whatbitcoindid, TFTC, Bankless. Fox primetime, Newsmax, NY Post editorial board.

B. TWELVE-WEEK ROLLOUT

- Weeks 1–2. Finalize this data room; secure written commitments from Tier 1 principals.
- Weeks 3–4. Pre-brief Republican Senate and House leadership; secure hold-open statements.
- Weeks 5–6. Ground game with Stand With Crypto — mobilize member outreach to swing-state senators.
- Weeks 7–8. Earned media saturation on Tier 3 platforms without naming the pardon; build the frame first.
- Week 9. Private brief delivered to the White House Counsel's office and Domestic Policy Council.
- Week 10. Announcement event; coordinated tweet storm; surrogates prepositioned.
- Weeks 11–12. Sustainment: op-eds, follow-on pardons if warranted, legislative codification.

C. WHAT YOU CAN DO TODAY

- If you know a Tier 1 or Tier 3 principal personally — email them today.
- If you run a podcast or a newsletter — cover the case this week; make the frame stick.
- If you have donor relationships — signal now that a pardon will be rewarded.
- If you are a lawyer — pressure-test the draft warrant in Doc 2 and send corrections.
- If you are a designer, editor, or researcher — help improve this data room for the next iteration.
- If you know somebody who knows the President — get this document into their hands.

D. WHAT WE ARE EXPLICITLY NOT DOING

- We are not asking for money for the defendants.
- We are not asking for changes in legislation as a precondition.
- We are not litigating this in court. We are asking the political branch to do its job.
- We are not attacking career civil servants. We are asking the President to lead.

E. CLOSING

Rome was not built in a day. Neither will this pardon be. But the window between now and the 2026 midterms is the best opportunity we will have before 2028. If we miss it, we do not miss it by a little — we miss it by two years, and by two years of prison for men who never should have seen a prosecutor.

The President has already shown, twice, that he will do the right thing on cases like this. The task now is to make sure this case reaches his desk with everything he needs to say yes.

Not Criminals: Two Developers Who Built Privacy Worth Having



Two developers, ten years of public, open-source work.

This section exists because the record has been distorted. Keonne Rodriguez and William "Bill" Lonergan Hill are not money launderers, not cartel bankers, and not operators of a criminal enterprise. They are two software developers — one 37, one 67 — who spent a decade building free, open-source tools so ordinary Bitcoin users could keep the same everyday financial privacy that cash has always provided.

A. WHO THEY ACTUALLY ARE

- Keonne Rodriguez — CEO and co-founder of Samourai Wallet, age 37, from Florida. An American developer, a husband and father, who co-founded the project in 2015 and spent ten years shipping open-source Bitcoin software in public, under his own name.
- William Lonergan Hill ("Bill") — CTO and co-founder, age 67. A career software engineer whose life's work has been non-custodial, privacy-preserving tools. At 67, a four-year federal sentence is a meaningful portion of the rest of his life.
- Both men are first-time offenders with zero criminal history. Neither resisted arrest. Neither fled. Neither hid.

B. WHAT THEY BUILT, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Samourai Wallet was a non-custodial Bitcoin wallet. Non-custodial means the software never held a single user's coins and never held a single user's private keys. Users' funds stayed in users' hands at all times. There was no vault, no omnibus account, no pool of customer money — none of the things that define a money transmitter in ordinary language or in ordinary law.

Bitcoin's ledger is fully public. Every payment you make is permanently visible to your employer, your landlord, your ex-spouse, a stalker, a kidnapper, or a data broker. Samourai's features — Whirlpool, Ricochet, Stonewall, PayNym — were engineering answers to that problem. They did for a public ledger what an envelope does for a letter: they did not change what you were doing, only who got to read it.

The code was published openly, in public repositories, for anyone to read, audit, fork, or criticize. Criminals do not publish their machinery on GitHub under their real names for ten years.

C. WHO PRIVACY TOOLS ACTUALLY PROTECT

- Domestic-violence survivors whose abusers should not be able to watch their spending.
- Journalists and their sources in countries where a payment trail is an arrest warrant.
- Dissidents, human-rights NGOs, and their donors under authoritarian regimes.
- Small businesses that do not want competitors reading their supplier payments.
- Ordinary families who simply do not want their salary, their medical payments, and their charitable giving indexed forever by strangers.

Financial privacy is not an exotic demand. It is the default condition of cash and has been for the entire history of the United States. Samourai's developers were restoring a norm, not inventing an escape hatch.

D. THE MISUSE ARGUMENT, ANSWERED

The government's own figures describe roughly \$2 billion in total volume processed through Samourai's coordination features over its lifetime, of which approximately \$237 million — about ten percent — was alleged to be tied to illicit activity. That means roughly ninety percent of the activity was lawful users protecting lawful transactions.

By that standard, every general-purpose technology in America is a crime scene. Cash, cars, encrypted messaging, email, the U.S. Postal Service, and the interstate highway system all carry a share of criminal use far above zero. We do not imprison the engineers.

Rep. Warren Davidson (R-OH) put it exactly: "It's like blaming Microsoft for drug cartels downloading and using Excel."

E. COOPERATION, NOT CONCEALMENT

- Arrested on 24 April 2024 in pre-dawn raids; neither man resisted.
- Strict compliance with every bail condition, with no violations alleged.

- Forfeiture of approximately \$6.4 million — effectively a decade of earnings.
- Nineteen months of restrictive home confinement before sentencing.
- No allegation that either man personally laundered funds, personally moved criminal proceeds, or personally handled a customer's coins.

F. THE CHARACTER CASE FOR CLEMENCY

A pardon here is not leniency for a criminal. It is a correction of a category error. These are builders who were told, in effect, that publishing useful code makes you responsible for every stranger who downloads it. If that principle stands, the person who writes the next generation of American financial software will write it somewhere else — or not at all.

Keonne Rodriguez and Bill Hill made Bitcoin privacy worth having. That is the whole of their offense.

The Case Record: Timeline, Charges, and Sentences

A. TIMELINE

- 2015 — Keonne Rodriguez and William Lonergan Hill co-found Samurai Wallet, an open-source, non-custodial Bitcoin wallet for Android.
- 2015–2024 — Development continues in public. Features include Whirlpool (a CoinJoin coordinator), Ricochet, Stonewall, and PayNym. The software is downloaded by users worldwide.
- Pre-indictment — FinCEN staff advise, in substance, that a non-custodial wallet of this type is not a money transmitter. The campaign's central factual allegation is that DOJ proceeded anyway.
- 24 April 2024 — Both men are arrested in early-morning, heavily armed raids. Rodriguez is arrested in Pennsylvania; Hill is arrested in Portugal. Samurai's servers and domain are seized.
- 2024–2025 — Roughly nineteen months of restrictive pretrial release. Defense alleges exculpatory FinCEN material was withheld for over a year — a Brady issue.
- 2025 — Both men plead guilty to conspiracy to operate an unlicensed money transmitting business. Forfeiture of approximately \$6.4 million.
- 6 November 2025 — Keonne Rodriguez is sentenced in the Southern District of New York to five years in prison — the statutory maximum — plus a \$250,000 fine and three years of supervised release.
- 19 November 2025 — William Lonergan Hill is sentenced to four years in prison, a \$250,000 fine, and three years of supervised release.
- 2026 — A public pardon campaign forms around freesamurai.com and billandkeonne.org. The President is reported to be aware of the case and to have said he would look into a pardon.

B. THE CHARGES

The operative counts were conspiracy to commit money laundering (18 U.S.C. § 1956(h)) and conspiracy to operate an unlicensed money transmitting business (18 U.S.C. § 1960, charged with § 371). The § 1960 theory is the load-bearing one: it treats the authors and operators of a coordination server for a non-custodial wallet as if they were running a money services business, notwithstanding that they never accepted, held, or controlled customer funds.

C. THE THREE STRUCTURAL PROBLEMS

- Custody. Section 1960 and the FinCEN guidance built on it turn on acceptance and transmission of funds. Samurai accepted nothing and transmitted nothing; it published software and coordinated transactions its users signed themselves.
- Notice. The developers relied on the agency's own published guidance and on counsel. A prosecution that contradicts the regulator's stated interpretation, with no prior warning letter, offers no fair notice.

- Disclosure. The allegation that FinCEN's pre-indictment view was withheld from the defense for more than a year is not a technicality; it goes to whether the plea was informed.

D. PROPORTIONALITY

Major regulated banks have resolved industrial-scale money-laundering failures — including cases involving cartel proceeds — through corporate fines and deferred prosecution agreements, with no individual imprisoned. Two developers who never touched a customer's money received nine combined years of federal prison. Whatever one thinks of the underlying legal theory, that ratio is impossible to defend in public.

The Public Campaign: Sites, Petition, and Support Infrastructure



A distributed campaign: three sites, one ask.

A. FREESAMOURAI.COM

The campaign's public record of the case. It presents the core fact plainly: for the first time in history, Bitcoin developers have been arrested and convicted for developing a non-custodial Bitcoin wallet. The site collects the case history, press coverage, video interviews, recommended reading, and the projects that continue the work, and it routes visitors to the petition and to the family fund.

B. BILLANDKEONNE.ORG

The family-facing site — "Behind Every Line of Code, There's a Family." It supports Bill, Keonne, and their loved ones through direct donations, including Bitcoin and other cryptocurrency. It is also where the campaign posts status updates, including the report that President Trump is aware of the case and has said he will look into a pardon.

C. THE CHANGE.ORG PETITION

"Stand Up for Freedom: Pardon the Innocent Coders Jailed for Building Privacy Tools!" — hosted on Change.org and carrying well over seventeen thousand verified signatures. The petition asks for a presidential pardon, DOJ oversight of the prosecution, and protective legislation such as the Blockchain Regulatory Certainty Act.

D. WHAT THE CAMPAIGN IS ASKING FOR

- A full and unconditional presidential pardon for both men.
- Oversight of the DOJ's handling of the case, including the withheld FinCEN material.
- Statutory clarity that publishing non-custodial software is not money transmission.
- Support for the families while the men are incarcerated.

E. HOW A READER CAN HELP IN FIVE MINUTES

- Sign the petition at change.org and send it to five people who will actually sign.
- Donate at billandkeonne.org — fiat, Bitcoin, or other crypto.
- Share one of the video interviews with an audience that is not already crypto-native.
- Contact your representative and ask them to state publicly that code is not custody.
- Send this data room to anyone with a line into the White House.

Voices: Lawmakers, Institutions, and Media

A. ON THE RECORD

"It's like blaming Microsoft for drug cartels downloading and using Excel." — Rep. Warren Davidson (R-OH)

"A chilling moment for financial privacy." — Cato Institute

"The Biden administration steamrolling the existing and longstanding interpretation of FinCEN is not only wrong on the law ... wallet software is no more to blame for illicit finance than a highway is responsible for a bank robber's getaway car." — Sen. Cynthia Lummis (R-WY)

"A delivery service that cannot access the underlying contents ... is plainly not a money transmitter." — Coin Center

B. COVERAGE AND LONG-FORM EXPLAINERS

- Natalie Brunell, Coin Stories — "Will Trump Pardon Samurai? Guilty Plea, Prison Ahead, and the Fight for Privacy in Bitcoin." A general-audience interview with Keonne Rodriguez.
- Kim Iversen — "US Govt Just Jailed Him for Protecting Your Privacy." A non-crypto political audience reacting to the facts of the case.
- Naomi Brockwell TV — "He Built a Privacy Tool. Now He's Going to Prison." A plain-language walkthrough for viewers new to the privacy fight.
- The Hated One — "Going to PRISON for extreme privacy." Long-form interview with Keonne Rodriguez.
- ReasonTV — "This app makes bitcoin private. The feds hate it." Libertarian framing of the prosecution.

C. WHY THE MESSENGER SET MATTERS

The coalition here is unusually broad: Republican members of Congress, a Republican senator, libertarian think tanks, civil-liberties technologists, and left-leaning independent media all arrive at the same conclusion from different premises. That is the signature of a genuine miscarriage of justice rather than a partisan grievance — and it is what makes a pardon politically cheap and durable.

D. SOURCES

- freesamurai.com — public case record, coverage archive, and pardon appeal.
- billandkeonne.org — family support fund and campaign updates.
- change.org — "Stand Up for Freedom: Pardon the Innocent Coders Jailed for Building Privacy Tools!"
- U.S. Department of Justice, S.D.N.Y. filings in *United States v. Rodriguez and Hill*.

- Coin Center, Cato Institute, and public statements by Rep. Warren Davidson and Sen. Cynthia Lummis.